THE SUN KING'S NAVY



Battle of La Hogue
The disastrous series of actions in 1692 resulted in the burning of 12 French ships of the line. It put an end to Louis XIV's plan to give naval support to an invasion of England by the deposed Catholic monarch James II.

IN THE COURSE of the 17th century the kings of France made their country the dominant land power in Europe, but maritime affairs traditionally had less importance for the French than for the English or the Dutch. It was not until the reign of the "Sun King" Louis XIV that a thoroughgoing effort was initiated to turn France into an oceanic power. From the 1660s the Sun King's principal minister, Jean-Baptiste Colbert, embarked on a programme of naval expansion that went hand in hand with the development of overseas colonies and maritime commerce. France had a sufficient population of seamen, greater resources than any other contemporary European state, and a powerful centralized administration. What it turned out to lack was the political will to sustain world-beating naval forces. After promising beginnings, the Sun King's navy in effect conceded command of the seas to the British.

COLBERT'S ACHIEVEMENT

Cardinal Richelieu, principal minister of King Louis XIII, had made an initial move to build up French naval forces in the 1620s, but both ships and shore facilities had subsequently fallen into disrepair. Colbert thus had to start almost from scratch. His aim was to create a formidable force of warships with efficient crews and officers, supported by an effective infrastructure. To build the ships he at first brought in expertise from abroad, chiefly employing Dutch master shipwrights, but also the Englishman Anthony Deane and the Neapolitan Biagio Pangallo. Through this transfer of technology the French soon became fine shipbuilders in their own right. They favoured large three-deck ships of the line, decorated with magnificent figureheads and carvings by noted artists such as sculptor Pierre Puget. France's great military engineer Vauban was entrusted with the building and fortification of naval bases. Toulon was developed as the main Mediterranean port and Brest as the principal Atlantic naval base. These were backed up by less satisfactory facilities at Rochefort and Le Havre, and by Dunkirk, sold to France by the English in 1662. Colbert also promoted improvements in navigation and hydrography. Appearing after Colbert's death in the 1690s, the *Neptune Français* charts produced by French maritime surveyors were the best in Europe.

MEN AND OFFICERS

In 1668 Colbert instituted a rational system for the conscription of sailors into the navy. All seamen in France had to register – the "Inscription Maritime" – and men from the register were called up by rotation in "classes". Each class performed naval service for a fixed number of years. To make this compulsory service more palatable there were social benefits. The children of seamen on naval duty were educated free and there was also provision for sick pay. The sailors' wages were sent to their homes rather than paid on ship, preventing the men from spending it all on drink and loose women. Some officers were transferred from the army to the navy; others were recalled



Shipbuilding in the reign of Louis XIV
Colbert aimed to create a merchant marine to rival that of the Dutch, so that French trade would always be carried in French ships. A strong navy was essential to protect merchant shipping from Dutch, English, and other raiders.